NEW YORK STATE | Office of Information Technology Services

State Capitol P.O. Box 2062
Albany, NY 12220-0062
www.its.ny.gov

New York State Information Technology Standard	**No:** NYS-S16-001
IT Standard # New York State Universal Web Navigation	**Updated:** 01/15/25 **Issued By:** NYS Office of Information Technology Services (ITS) **Owner:** Office of Digital Transformation / NYS Design System Team

1.0 Purpose and Benefits

The purpose of this mandatory technology standard is to define a Universal Navigation to be used for all New York State government entities' public websites and web applications.

2.0 Authority

Section 103(10) of the State Technology Law provides the Office of Information Technology Services ("ITS") with the authority to establish statewide technology policies, including technology and security standards. *Section 2 of Executive Order No. 117*[1], established January 2002, provides the State Chief Information Officer with the authority to oversee, direct and coordinate the establishment of information technology policies, protocols and standards for State government, including hardware, software, security and business re-engineering. Details regarding this authority can be found in

[1] All references to Executive Order 117 refer to that which was originally issued by Governor George E. Pataki on January 28, 2002 and continued by Executive Order 5 issued by Governor Eliot Spitzer on January 1, 2007, Executive Order 9 issued by Governor David A. Patterson on June 18, 2008, and Executive Order 2 issued by Governor Andrew M. Cuomo on January 1, 2011 and Executive Order 6 issued by Governor Kathy Hochul on October 8, 2021.

NYS ITS Policy, *NYS-P08-002 Authority to Establish State Enterprise Information Technology (IT) Policy, Standards and Guidelines*.

3.0 Scope

This policy applies to all "State Entities" (SE), defined as "State Government" in Executive Order 117 or "State Agencies" as defined in Section 101 of the State Technology Law. This includes employees and all third parties (such as local governments, consultants, vendors, and contractors) that use or access any Information Technology (IT) Resource for which the SE or ITS has administrative responsibility, including systems managed or hosted by third parties on behalf of the SE or ITS. While an SE may adopt a different policy/standard, it must include the requirements set forth in this one. Where a conflict exists between this policy/standard and an SE's policy/standard, the more restrictive policy will take precedence.

4.0 Information Statement

The New York State Universal Navigation provides a consistent visual identity, with support for search and translation functionality, across all NYS websites.

The Universal Navigation includes header and footer elements for use on SE public websites. The Universal Navigation must be included on all SE public websites and web applications as defined below.

4.1 New York State Universal Navigation

The official embeddable code and implementation instructions are available in the "Universal Navigation (Next)" repository on the New York State GitHub account. Detailed guidelines and instructions for implementing the Universal Navigation are included in the repository and should be considered an extension of this standard. This repository also contains guidance, frequently asked questions, demos, and other resources to support implementation.

For scenarios where a website cannot use the standard embedded implementation of the Universal Navigation, an exception request must be submitted to the ITS Design System Team using the Universal Navigation (UNav) Intake Form. This ensures that express permission is provided for exceptions and a record of sites not using the embed is maintained.

4.2 Universal Navigation Size

The Universal Navigation must extend the full width of a web page with no gaps between elements and the browser or application window edges unless a specific exception is approved in writing. Responsive design techniques are used to scale appropriately for

different devices, including desktops, tablets, and mobile phones, provided the site or application is also designed responsively.

4.3 Universal Navigation Design

The Universal Navigation is designed to blend with NYS websites and web applications and cannot be altered visually or functionally, except for the approved settings available through configuration options that are defined in the technical documentation. Any other modifications require an approved exception. Existing websites should continue to follow the established NYS Branding Guidelines.

4.4 Placement of the Universal Navigation

The Universal Navigation must appear at the top of every page on the SE's public websites and web applications. Nothing should appear above the Universal Navigation in the browser or application window. Additional edits cannot be made to alter the appearance of the Universal Navigation, including additional links. No elements of the native webpage or application should overlap the container element of the Universal Navigation.

4.5 Intranet and Non-Public Facing Sites or Applications

While not required, intranet websites, extranets, and other non-public facing sites or applications may include the Universal Navigation if it enhances the user experience.

4.6 Functionality and Updates to the Universal Navigation

Functionality of the Universal Navigation should be tested in a development environment before deploying. If problems arise when implementing the standard version, check the repository for troubleshooting guidance and support resources.

Updates to the Universal Navigation occur periodically. In general, a testing period will precede the official deployment of updates. Development teams should test updates to the Universal Navigation in development environments and submit problems or concerns through the UNav Intake Form.

4.7 Including Accessibility Features

The Universal Navigation is designed to work with various accessibility requirements. A "skip to content" or "skip to navigation" link can be used at the top of a webpage to aid visitors using screen readers or with limited motor abilities.

When possible, a "skip to content" link should:

1. Remain hidden from normal view until engaged, with no space between the Universal Navigation header element and the top of the web page or application.

2. Act as the initial link for screen readers.

3. Appear when common accessibility practices are engaged.

4.8 Domain and Encryption Requirements

The Universal Navigation includes messaging that explains how to identify an official ny.gov website by both the .gov domain and HTTPS encryption. This is an emerging pattern for official websites at all levels of government.

The Universal Navigation may ONLY be used on websites or applications with a ny.gov domain that are secured with HTTPS encryption. Existing websites or applications that do not meet these requirements and have the Universal Navigation embedded on their websites must either be compliant by March 15, 2025 or request an exemption from the ITS Design System Team. Technical measures may be implemented after this date to prevent non-compliant sites from embedding the Universal Navigation script.

Websites or web applications that are unable to meet these requirements cannot use the embedded version of the Universal Navigation. However, a modified, recreated version of the navigation bar may be permitted under certain circumstances. To request an exception, submit a request to the ITS Design System Team via the UNav Intake Form.

5.0 Compliance

This standard shall take effect upon publication. Compliance is required with all enterprise policies and standards. ITS may amend its policies and standards at any time; compliance with amended policies and standards is required.

If compliance with this standard is not feasible or technically possible, or if deviation from this standard is necessary to support a business function, SEs shall request an exception through the ITS Design System Team's exception process via the UNav Intake Form.

ITS may also assess SE compliance with this standard. To accomplish this assessment, ITS may issue, from time to time, requests for information to SEs, which will be used to develop any reporting requirements as may be requested by the NYS Chief Information Officer, the Executive Chamber, or Legislative entities.

6.0 Definitions of Key Terms

Except for terms defined in this policy, all terms shall have the meanings found in the ITS Glossary.

7.0 Contact Information

Submit all inquiries & requests for future enhancements regarding this standard to:

NYS Design System
Office of Digital Transformation
Reference: NYS-S16-001
NYS Office of Information Technology Services
State Capitol, ESP, P.O. Box 2062
Albany, NY 12220

Inquiries may also be directed to DesignSystem@its.ny.gov.

The State of New York Enterprise IT Policies may be found at the following website:
https://its.ny.gov/policies

8.0 Revision History

This policy should be reviewed consistent with the requirements set forth in ITS-P24-003 Process for Establishing Information Technology Polices, Standards and Guidelines.

Date	Description of Change	Reviewer
April 15,2016	Original Policy issued to replace NYS-S05-001 State Common Web Banner	WebNY
01/25/2025	Updated to include *.ny.gov and HTTPS requirement, revision to scope and authority, cursory review to remaining document.	NYS Design System Team

9.0 Related Documents

New York State GitHub Repository for the updated Universal Navigation:
https://github.com/ITS-HCD/unav-next